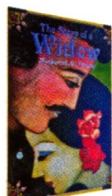


Life in Slow MOTION

This love story of a widow set in Karachi gets a Jane Austen treatment



THE STORY OF A WIDOW

by MUSHARRAF ALI FAROOQI
Picador
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 249

By Bunny Suraiya |

This is a gem of a book and the author is a real find. At last the subcontinent can rejoice in having acquired its own avatar of the iconic Jane Austen who, with a mere half-a-dozen novels to her credit, introduced the world to a new style of literature rooted in the seemingly mundane, but breathtaking in its insights and delightful in its humour. Musharraf Ali Farooqi is an able successor in this genre. Here

is the same keen observation of social mores, the sympathy for human foibles, the rapier-like wit that makes one laugh aloud and the simple, elegant prose in which it is all expressed.

The eponymous widow of the tale is Mona, a 50-something woman in Karachi with two married daughters and a comfortable financial independence after the death of her husband, which releases her from the frugalities she was compelled by his miserly nature to practice during his lifetime. "Shocked to find out how much money Akbar Ahmad had left behind... it took Mona some time to become accustomed to the idea that she had ready access to that money and no longer had to consult her conscience or ask Akbar Ahmad's permission to spend it."

Despite beginning to feel rather badly done by during her 31 years of married life, which were dictated, she realises in hindsight, by Ahmad's petty tyrannies, Mona nevertheless follows convention and hangs up her late husband's portrait in the living room, from where it gazes down at her with varying expressions of disapproval, annoyance, rage—and sometimes even

unseemly glee at her failures to cope with the situation caused by the third part of her marital triangle, Salamat Ali, the tenant from next door and the most unsuitable suitor for a woman of principle such as Mona certainly is.

This love triangle—or more correctly, love tangle—sets Mona at odds with her family: her daughters Tanya and Amber and their respective husbands, her sister and brother-in-law, Hina and Jafar and the uncle who raised her after her own parents died, Sajid Mir, whose acidic wife, Aunt Aneesa has never forgiven Mona for being prettier than her own daughter of the same age, the still-unmarried Rubab.

The calm rhythm of Mona's life is upset as she unceasingly questions her own heart and motives, trying to balance her misgivings regarding the wickedly funny but also often impertinent Ali with

the wild delight she finds in his frank admiration of her as a sexually desirable woman. During the trials and tribulations that follow upon Ali's marriage proposal to Mona, the nuances of family relationships are minutely explored, culture and tradition impartially observed and hypocrisies exposed by Farooqi's profoundly perceptive eye.

In true Austenian fashion, the action takes place in drawing rooms, at dinner tables, during birthday and anniversary celebrations and other social get-togethers, but so varied is the emotional canvas that there is never a moment of claustrophobia for the reader; indeed, one wishes to get to know the characters more closely and regrets the loss of their companionship when the story ends. The conversations are true-to-life and there is a glorious set piece in which Mona, goaded beyond endurance, takes on the obnoxious Aunt Aneesa in a verbal battle reminiscent of that between Elizabeth Bennet and the insufferable Lady Catherine de Burgh in *Pride and Prejudice*. Bravo!

SAURABH SINGH



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